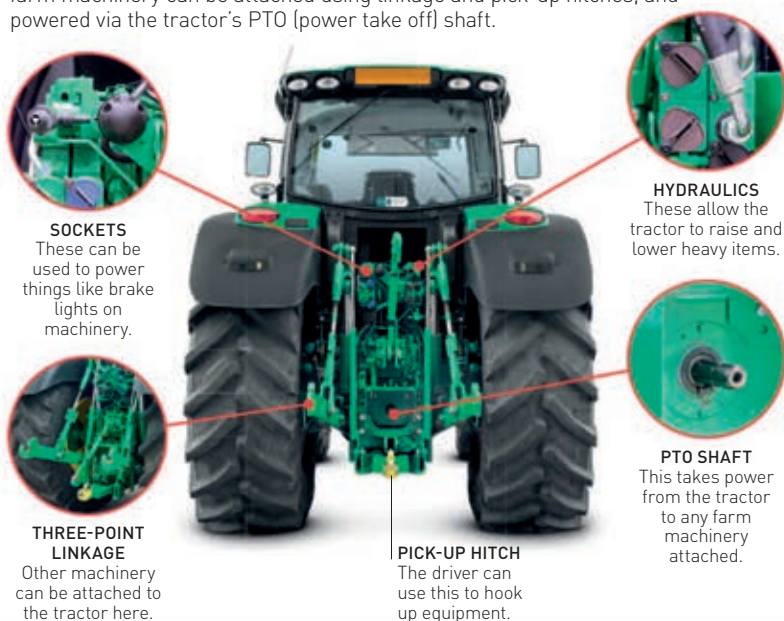


Tractors

A tractor is a vehicle designed to pull things – especially large farm machinery. Tractors have engines with a special gearbox that allows them to use all the engine's power for strength, not speed. Once fuelled by coal, they now run on diesel.

MODERN MACHINE ANATOMY

Modern tractors are very large and powerful. They have four huge wheels with grooved tyres that allow them to travel over wet, muddy ground, and reinforced cabs to keep the driver safe even if the tractor tips over. Other farm machinery can be attached using linkage and pick-up hitches, and powered via the tractor's PTO (power take off) shaft.



A YEAR ON THE FARM

Farmers work with the seasons, as seeds and crops will grow only when conditions are right. Tractors are useful at every stage of the process, from preparing the land to harvesting the crops.

1 PLOUGHING AND CULTIVATING

After the harvest, tractors are used to pull ploughs, preparing the soil for seeding.

2 PLANTING SEEDS

Seeds are sown on to the fields using a tractor seeder. Modern machines make sure that lines of seeds don't overlap.

4 HARVESTING

Farmers attach special machinery, such as combines and forage harvesters, to tractors to harvest the crops (such as wheat) from the fields.

3 SPRAYING FERTILIZERS

Fertilizer spreaders are attached to tractors to distribute growth-enhancing fertilizer across the fields.

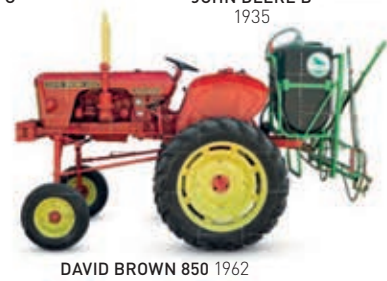
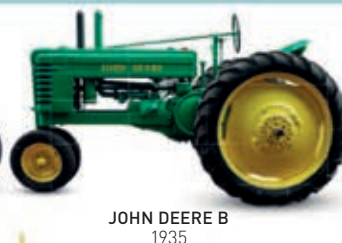
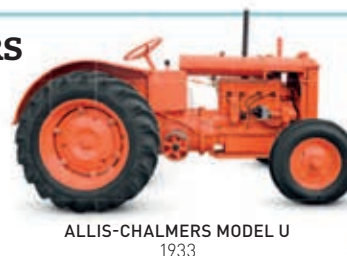
FIRST TRACTORS

Tractors were invented in the 1860s to do the job of horses around the farm. They had steam engines, large metal wheels, and a seat at the back.



FARM TRACTORS

Petrol tractors were invented in the 1890s, with wheels designed to give them great pulling power. They were also faster, and quickly became indispensable on farms.



CRAWLERS

From the 1920s farms also began to use the "crawler" or "caterpillar". These have tracks rather than wheels and can travel safely over slippery ground and steep hills.

